Stability of L1 and L2 word association responses over time and across response positions

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Abstract: This study explores the concept of associative stability (AS) in both first language (L1) and second language (L2), defined as the repetition rate of word association responses across two administrations of the same test. The research focuses on comparing L1 and L2 AS patterns, examining correlations in AS between the two languages within individual learners, and assessing the effect of response position on AS. Forty Chinese learners of English completed two word association tasks with a two-week interval in each language, providing three responses to each cue word. Key findings include (1) a significantly higher repetition rate in L2 responses compared to L1; (2) a strong within-participant correlation between L1 and L2 response repetition; and (3) a notable effect of response position, with repetition rates decreasing from the first to third response position in both languages. These results suggest a level of intra-individual consistency in word association across languages while highlighting differences in the organization of L1 and L2 lexicons, which are likely attributable to the weaker structure of the L2 semantic network.

Keywords: Associative stability, response position, word association, mental lexicon

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